University Of Lincolnshire And Humberside.

FROM PrOTeSt TO PRODUCT?

Popular Music, Culture And Ideology.

Being An Independent Study Submitted In Partial Fulfillment Of The Requirements For The Degree Of:

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By Aaron Downing

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From Protest To Product? Popular Music, Culture And Ideology. An independent study by Aaron Downing (Ron Nasty of Hovercraft), submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of BA (Hons) Applied Social Science, University of Lincolnshire and Humberside, March 1999.

This is a scan of Ron's original bound copy, presented as written in 1999, including the period terminology and the 1999 web addresses, most of which no longer exist.

For this web edition, pages reproducing other people's copyright material have been left out. The page numbers printed on the remaining pages are the originals, so the gaps show where they were:

- Pictures 1–3: photographs of Bessie Smith, Blind Lemon Jefferson, Johnny Watson, Fats Domino and Smiley Lewis (from Harrison, 1994).
- Pictures 4–8: photographs of Johnny Rotten and the Sex Pistols, and images of youth and text (from Lydon, 1994; Savage, 1991; Hebdige, 1988).
- Appendix 4: Billie Holiday, *Strange Fruit* (lyrics).
- Appendix 5: The Sex Pistols, *God Save The Queen* (lyrics).
- Appendix 6: The Bill Grundy interview, a transcript (Thames Television, 1 December 1976).
- Appendix 7: EMI Annual General Meeting, 7 December 1976.

Everything else, including Ron's text, Appendices 1–3, the bibliography, internet references and discography, appears as submitted.

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ABSTRACT

The aim of the study is to determine whether or not dominant ideologies manipulate popular forms of music to express their own, or to suppress others', values and is expressed in the hypothesis that - *there is a clear and identifiable link between music, culture and ideology*. This supposition is initially investigated via a historical study of the musical form the Blues and covers its commercialisation and standardisation by the recording industry. Also, the fracturing of the Blues into different styles is investigated and an analysis of lyrical content is undertaken to show how the use of song can be used as a form of social protest and cultural homogenisation. This theme runs through the whole of the study.

Chapter Three discusses mass product, consumer culture and returns to the popular culture debate, briefly discussed in Chapter One. These two chapters discuss the tensions between Neo-Marxism and traditional Marxist thought, and attempts to reconcile the use of reducing genres to general terms. An explanation is then offered to show that reductionist terms may disguise the fracturing of society which may have been caused in part by industrialisation. This then leads the study into the arena of sub-cultures.

Youth culture is briefly discussed and an investigation is made into a recent spectacular youth sub-cultural phenomenon Punk Rock. Its social protest and relevance within its time and place and also its commercialisation by media and the record industry is also investigated. The importance of this section is in transposing the development of the blues as a socio-cultural music onto that of recent socio-cultural musics in order to identify similar patterns, e.g. recession, unemployment, migration, industrialisation and class. Content of song, its use of, for instance, biblical motifs in expression is also important here and can be seen first hand by referring to the appendices.

The conclusion is not conclusive in regard to the offered hypothesis. However, patterns and themes do tend to reoccur and the conclusion attempts to identify these. The appendices is of primary importance in this study and I would suggest that they are reffered to or possibly read before the main text.

FROM PROTEST TO PRODUCT?

An Independent Study by Aaron Downing.

AN INTRODUCTION TO THE STUDY: POPULAR MUSIC, CULTURE AND IDEOLOGY.

In regard to this particular study the shaping of pop music will come under scrutiny, due in the main to its massive availability to youth at all levels of society. This throws up many questions that I hope to identify in due course and offer an explanation for in as an objective a manner as possible. To begin with it is necessary to understand exactly what popular culture is and then make a distinction between the classifications "popular music" and "pop music." An investigation must then be made as to what is termed "culture", "mass/popular culture/society," "subculture" and "youth culture," to determine whether there are links between each and also what their opposing values may be. The conclusion will summarise the evidence found and compare it to the study's hypothesis that "there is a clear and identifiable link between music, culture and ideology". That is, through music a subculture may emerge that threatens the resident political ideology and that for this threat to be neutralised the subculture must be absorbed into mainstream society or removed by force. The main issue of this study, therefore, is to determine whether or not dominant political ideologies manipulate popular forms of music to express their own, or to suppress, others' values.

Abercombie, Hill and Turner define popular culture as 'loosely referring to ... the culture of the masses or of subordinate classes,' (Abercombie, Hill and Turner, 1994, p320). As we can determine there are two recognisable alternatives within the definition and therefore two unsurprisingly 'theoretical divisions in the study of popular culture,' (Abercombie, Hill and Turner, p320, 1994). Firstly, that of the critics such as the

Frankfurt School, a neo-Marxist institution of social research, which, amongst other things 'emphasised the importance of culture rather than economics and produced influential studies of music, literature and aesthetics,' (Abercombie, Hill and Turner, p173, 1994). They deem popular culture as being 'trivial, commercialized and passive,' (Abercombie, Hill and Turner, 1994, p320), and equate it with "mass culture." In opposition is the Birmingham cultural studies school of thought that perceives popular culture as being 'creative and authentic. There is also disagreement as to whether popular culture is a specific product of modern urban society or whether it is appropriate to refer to ... the popular culture of the Middle Ages,' (Abercombie et al, 1994, p320), for example.

This study will attempt to compare and contrast these two modes of thought. That is, the supposition that popular culture 'is an oppositional movement, challenging conventional tastes and values, or whether it is conservative and commercialised,' (Abercombie et al, p320, 1994). This will begin with a study of popular music within the offered definitions of popular culture and also look at whether or not, through 'the monopolization of the market and pop groups by large corporations,' (Abercombie et al, p320, 1994), a "mass market" has been created that generally removes meaning from lyrics and standardises music as a palatable and safe product. We will begin by defining popular and pop music and trace a little of the history of what is determined as being the first (modern) form of "pop music," namely "The Blues" and conclude with a link to that of, if not contemporary, certainly a recent musical pop phenomenon, "Punk Rock."

The methodology used to attempt to discover whether meaning is lost or not within pop music will be that of Discourse Analysis. Comparisons of content between a song from the Afro-American blues tradition, *"Strange Fruit,"* performed by Billie Holiday, and one from the British punk tradition, *"God Save The Queen,"* performed by the Sex Pistols can be undertaken in full by refering to the appendices. The study is then, to an extent, a cross-cultural one. Comparative and content analysis methods will be used during the construction of the investigation as well as being used in the final stages of the study. Strong historical content therefore becomes primary as knowing what was happening at particular times and in particular places may give us an understanding of what the social relevance and inherent meaning of songs are and this will remain a constant theme within the study.

CHAPTER ONE

Popular Music

Pop Or Popular?

Hatch and Millward in their introduction to "*From Blues To Rock - An Analytical History Of Pop Music*" define the use of the term "pop music" 'as locating a music which is distinguishable from popular, jazz and folk musics [sic], though obviously having connections with all of these through out its development,' (Hatch and Millward, 1987, p1). Pop music under this analysis can therefore be deemed a hybrid of popular music in that it borrows and improvises musical standards to create a populist form. That is, 'pop music ... is primarily an aural and improvised music ... learnt through "live" performances, radio and television broadcasts and, especially, gramophone records,' (Hatch and Millward, 1987, p1), audio tapes and CD's. It has, as Hatch and Millward suggest, a parallel yet indirect link with jazz, the most obvious being that they share 'a common folk music ancestry,' (Hatch and Millward, 1987, p1). The observable difference between the two is that jazz commonly borrows from popular music, which is defined as being:

'the music associated especially with Tin Pan Alley and the sheet music publishing industry, and also with Broadway and the "musical show," plus cinematic connections with these traditions through the Hollywood musical,' (Hatch and Millward, 1987, p1).

Under Hatch and Millward's analysis "popular" and "pop" are related but are also distinctly different musical forms, jazz being the most perceptible link between the two concepts due to its folk music connections. The differences most highlighted are that pop music is that of oral/aural tradition and popular music being that of written tradition. "Pop" may therefore be perceived as being the music of the masses and "popular" being within a lower-middle-class realm with pretensions to upper-middle classdom; "classical" possibly being perceived as elitist, aesthetic, timeless and meaningful music. To keep it simple, popular music can therefore be defined as being that of "sheet music" which automatically creates a perceptible difference between "pop" and "popular" in status, under the analysis that for popular music to be performed the ability to read musical scores is necessary. An analysis that ties in with Adorno and the Frankfurt School's of reasoning and may be a purely subjective viewpoint. It is rational none-the-less and gives us an idea of structure and supposed hierarchy.

Pop music then appears to have inextricable links with folk music through its oral/aural tradition, and according to Paul Oliver: "If Mamie Smith had never entered a recording studio [in 1920], if the blues had never been recorded in any form, it would have thrived as a folk music," (Oliver, 1990, p1). Hatch and Millward also argue a similar case when attempting, in much detail, to define the blues. They state that defining the blues is difficult and that the problem is usually solved by 'consigning blues recorded before various dates (from around 1935 onwards) to the "folk" category, or alternatively, reserving the "folk blues" category for the variety accompanied by acoustic instruments and having some rural connections,' (Hatch and Millward, 1987, p12). However, such categorisation does not allow for the 'dissemination of blues songs and styles ... via records and radio programmes in the 1920's,' (Hatch and Millward, 1987, p12), such as

That Thing Called Love by Mamie Smith in 1920 and 'the recording of Bradford's *Crazy Blues*, [performed by Smith in the same year], with it's choruses based on a twelve-bar structure, the first vocal recording to employ a blues form,' (Oliver, 1990, p1). This form however is recognised only as a standard; there are many other rhythms within the blues. The twelve-bar pattern is merely the most popular, copied and easily recognised form, suggesting that replication and standardisation are inherently related to commercialisation and by definition "pop" music of all genres.

Commercialisation And Mass Media

Hatch and Millward recognise this by stating that within their definition of the blues, pop music commenced with the advent of commercial recordings and radio broadcasts of the various regionally-located music's of the Southern U.S. states during the 1920's and this is born out by the sales of *Crazy Blues* which sold '7, 500 copies a week, revealing the existence of a market that the record companies were not slow to exploit. In Alberta Hunter's words, "Mamie Smith had made it possible for all of us,"' (Oliver, 1990, p1), in the respect of making accessible the opportunity to perform and sell recordings of the blues. However, according to Baraka this form of the blues, or black music, 'was ... the shallow fakery of Tin Pan Alley,' (Baraka, 1982, p184), and not a true reflection of Afro-American music, it was merely a bland, populist form. Quite possibly siding with the Frankfurt Schools analysis of pop music in that it lent itself to industrial techniques of standardisation espoused by the likes of Taylor and Ford - "You can have any blues you like as long as its the blues we produce!"

This leads us to the analysis that without commercial recording interest in the blues the blues would not have developed in the populist way that it did and arguably remains so.

That is, Mamie Smith's songs, according to Oliver, 'were on the very fringe of the blues, half-Vaudeville performances which marked a late stage in the development of the blues from a simple folk music to a form of sophisticated entertainment,' (Oliver, 1990, p1). It was not the true blues it was simply a safe, palatable, product arguably composed by and performed for a white market, (the musicians on Mamie Smith's first recording were all white). It was not until later that a black market was found for the Country Blues. The true form under a traditional Marxist analysis remaining the folk form that had a shared, communal ownership. Hatch and Millward support this, commenting that:

'the emergence of the blues as a recognisable type of music ... in the popular music world [followed] **the publication and widespread acceptance of W.C. Handy's** [written] **compostions, just after the First World War, and the use of the label "blues" in the title of numerous vaudeville songs,** [and that] **the influence of ... vaudeville singers, particularly Bessie Smith, on country blues musicians has probably been underestimated ...,'** (Hatch and Millward, 1987, pp12-13).

Harrison also, who states:

'It was the recording of the blues that changed the music irrevocably. Once the music became easily available in shops or by mail order, it became difficult to trace the originator of a popular song ...,' (Harrison, 1995, p19).

And Georgia Tom Dorsey, bluesman, who admitted that before blues were recorded there was usually a communal ownership of blues music:

"Blues was blues. All blues belong to you ... All blues sounded alike for a while anyway, so we never bothered about the other fellow," (Dorsey cited Harrison, 1995, p20).

The relationship appears to be that vaudeville blues, (also known as "Classic Blues"), initially grew out of folk/country blues and as it became established it in turn influenced, through its own genesis, that of the original influence. A fairly complex inter-relationship appears to be at work here showing a difference in forms. The folk tradition influences the popular "vaudeville" blues via the use of folk standards that are performed in a more accessible, although more sophisticated form, to a larger audience. The sophistication and use of standards are passed back to the folk tradition creating a form that sits between the two; a form we could determine as being "pop." In analysis a dilution of the authentic and dilution of the sophisticated. In a manner of speaking a dialectical is taking place, the "pop" form being the synthesis and most "popular," although most dilute form. It becomes a commercially viable, standardised, mainstream product.

Under the Frankfurt Schools mode of reasoning "pop" is not authentic and is therefore meaningless, apart from its obvious commercial and economic potential. Classical music on the other hand is unpopular, although it is deemed aesthetic, meaningful and authentic. It is unconcerned with its economic viability; it is, after all, art! Folk music must also fall into this categorisation as in its origins it is meaningful and authentic and is limited in its economic viability, until it becomes "pop" or "popular." In the case of country blues its exponents would often play at social gatherings for drinks, food and shelter in return for supplying entertainment for the evening. Or in the days of slavery play for no payment except that of entertaining fellow slaves on the plantation one evening a week, (a Saturday). A custom that was maintained and continued during the migration of Afro-Americans to the industrial cities of North America where its form changed to that of the urban blues; a reflection of environmental and social change.

Classical music is regarded as being the music of high culture and definitively European, pop being the music of low or "mass" culture. Classical music is therefore a music played by and for the elite, pop music being played by and for the masses. What then of folk music? In its evolution folk lent to pop which also borrowed from more "sophisticated" forms, leaving folk as a marginal music. Folk music becomes "unpopular" economically as well as socially in the same way as classical music does. Folk music must therefore, under this analogy, become "elitist" in the same way as classical music does and must be equated, as classical music, in being aesthetic, meaningful and timeless. In short, a form that is civilising although it is regarded as being primitive. The Frankfurt School appears to overlook the fact that any form of music is popular with somebody, it is therefore obsolete in determining what is meaningful or unmeaningful, cultured or primitive, fine art or low art, as all art, in some form must lend toward civilisation. It is therefore observable that there is a tension between neo-Marxist and traditional Marxist thought.

Neo-Marxism expresses a need to replicate European "bourgeois culture" to civilise/educate the proletariat. This expresses the belief that the European bourgeoisie are indeed the elite and by definition the legitimate controllers, or "gatekeepers," of all that is good in society. It could be seen as Marxism shooting itself in the foot by believing that any synthesis will ultimately be conservative and unmeaningful. It also relies on the notion of "mass" or "popular" culture as being real and identifiable entities and assumes the masses are congregant within the working class districts of industrialised cities and maintains that agrarian areas are therefore primitive. This sets up a divisive geographical hierarchy where the urban working class may be seen as being more sophisticated than their agrarian counterparts. Hatch, Millward and Oliver's analysis of

the role of commercial recording studios in developing certain forms of the blues and making the music populist and commercially viable by using sophisticated technology is almost an admiitance that pop is a standardised form. That is, they admit that the blues, if not commercialised and packaged as a product, would have probably evolved in a different way. However its alternative evolution is almost entirely hypothetical although they state that the field recordings of Delta bluesmen Son House and Willie Brown for instance 'definitely have a more "folksy" [authentic] sound than earlier commercial recordings,' (Hatch and Millward, 1987, p11). This suggests that if commercial recording companies had not got hold of the blues it would have developed naturally rather than synthetically, although probably not in a populist form. Therefore, the question arises has the blues lost its meaning through the commercial interests of the record industry?

CHAPTER 2

The Blues: A Socio-Cultural History

The Meaning Of The Blues

"The most distinctive feature of United States history is Afro-American slavery and its consequences. This truth is at the heart of our political, economic and social experience as a nation-state. It is also at the heart of our *cultural* experience, and therefore the slave narrative," (for instance) "is not peripheral but central to American culture," (Franklin cited Baraka, 1982, p178).

Defining and finding a meaning in the "Blues" is a complex task. Paul Oliver describes the blues as 'the personal emotion of the individual finding through music a vehicle for self-expression.' He also describes it as a 'social music ... the music of a class within a segregated group,' (Oliver, 1990, p3). The Blues exponent B. B. King describes it as 'the music of my people, the black residents of America, but it speaks to the world,' (King cited Harrison, 1995, p7). Amiri Baraka talks about the blues and its close relative jazz as being 'historically and originally black musics, or part of the Afro-American musical tradition,' (Baraka, 1982, p177), therefore in agreement with B.B. King and Paul Oliver. Paul Oliver, again, states that the blues had 'an ancestory that extends back into the 19th Century and ... into the slavery period,' (Oliver, 1990, p3), as Baraka also states, (1982). Joseph Machlis believes that the blues '"is a native American musical form with no direct European and African antecedents of which we know." In other words it is a blending of both traditions,' (Machlis cited Baker, 1991, p1), a view taken by many commentators on the blues. So, it appears the blues is arguably a form of music created via a mixture of traditions of which we can trace historically. It also suggests that it is, to an extent, a universal music with a universal message as well as being a socio-cultural and individual

music, in that it is a musical form that expresses the feelings and emotions of a specific culture and also the feelings and emotions of the individual performers. It may also be described as being the music of the oppressed and therefore a music of protest and the cultural homogenisation of a lower stratified class. So the questions - what is the meaning in the blues, is it specifically a black music that acts as a cultural social glue, is it a reactionary/protest music and if so what is it a reaction/protest against - must be investigated via a brief historical on the making of the music.

A Black Music?

We know that America was heavily populated by Europeans from the 15th Century onwards, who would have brought with them their own specific traditions and music. Many commentators on the blues have therefore suggested that American folk music has grown from Scottish, English, Irish, German, French, Spanish, Native American and African forms of traditional folk music. In the case of the blues, (described as being an Afro-American music), it becomes distinctive as a so-called "black music" due to the exponents of the music being originally and almost in totality, Afro-Americans.

The black population of America is inherently tied in with the slave trade of the 16th-19th centuries where over 15million Africans were enslaved and transported across the Atlantic ocean, (Giddens, 1981, p254). The majority of whom ended up working in the fields, (generally, although not exclusively, cotton), of the deep Southern states of North America, e.g. the Mississippi Delta. These people, who had been 'torn from their homes, shipped across the Atlantic ... in appalling conditions, and sold with brutal disregard for family ties,' (Harrison, 1995, p11), can quite easily be regarded as the most dispossesed

and oppressed members of American society. It must also be said that the Afro-American population should be regarded as a culture in their own right. A sub-culture of the majority white European society within which they had been forced to live, work and obey, and as such would inevitably come into contact with, and assimilate strands of, white European culture. Music, language and religion probably being amongst the most visible.

It is also observable that the colonisation and partitioning of Africa, (during the same period as America was being colonised), that Africans were being subjected to white European culture, religion and traditions in their own homeland. These Europeans were, on the whole, the same peoples that were trading in slaves and colonising America; therefore exposure to European culture for the majority of Africans was almost inevitable. It would then appear logical, under these circumstances, to make the supposition that African and European forms of music and culture would have been influenced, even if minutely, by each other. Through the contact of these diverse mixtures of people, traditions and music a new American cultural music appeared performed in general by Afro-Americans. Hence we arrive at the conclusion that the blues is an African American form of music, although it would take some considerable time before it gelled and became the generic term we use and know now as the blues.

The Emergence Of The Blues

There is much debate as to when the blues as a distinct form of music emerged, although most commentators agree that it would have been between the late 1800's and 1920. In the case of Hatch and Millward 1935 appears as the defining date due, in the main, to it becoming a viable, mass produced, commercial product made accessible via the advent of sophisticated recording techniques, the radio and phonograph. The blues/music had, under this analysis, become subject to Fordist mass production techniques. However, it's emergence as a dedicated/folk/authentic rather than "pop" form is believed to have 'coincided with the worsening of the social and economic conditions for blacks in the South,' (Crosby, 1999, p20), after the perceived emancipation, (See Appendix 2), of the slave due to the American Civil War, (1861-65), and up to the middle of the 20th Century.[1] The content of the songs often reflecting their brutal treatment and 'tales of personal experience on plantations and prison farms,' (Crosby, 1999, p2), as well as maintaining traditional oral folklore, fable and myth. Amiri Baraka's definition summarises what the blues is and what the blues is about:

'Blues carries with it Africa and Afro-America, shaped in a land of white domination. It carries slavery and degradation, and both the memory of Africa, and the reality of the African-American developing a further variation of African culture ... an amalgam of African as well as European ... and Native American elements,' (Baraka, 1982, pp117-118).

[1] 1952-1955 is often cited and can be linked to the birth of the "teenager," the emergence of rock 'n' roll, Bill Haley and Elvis Presley, the white and more acceptable Euro-American faces of the blues.

The Blues Tradition - A Content Analysis

The forms that have generally been associated with the blues are derived from an original West African tradition of the "griots." The griots have been described as an oral tradition that passes down from generation to generation the culture, histories and stories of their tribes to one another. In effect passing on the knowledge via language, in much the same way as the written word does in contemporary society, to their descendants; and according to Barlow:

'African American songsters who synthesised the blues from earlier genres of black folk music were descendants of the griots, carrying forward the historical and cultural legacy of their people even while they were setting a new agenda for political discourse and action,' (Barlow cited Crosby, 1999, p3).

The new griots were a continuation of African oral tradition and 'through their songs, they often expressed discontent with their situation and their hope for change,' (Crosby, 1999, p3). These expressions of discontent and hope for change give us the term "blues." A term of apparent English descent meaning a type of feeling, evolving 'into the name for the type of music,' (Crosby, 1999, p5), and remaining central themes of the music. The griot tradition therefore becomes the hardcore upon which an amalgamation of other related musical forms build upon.

The most usual form expressed as being the base within the blues are Spirituals or "Sorrow Songs." A form that expresses a longing for freedom, a "sigh of the oppressed." Many use 'biblical motifs and characters [and speak of] redemption and hope of eventual triumph and freedom,' (Crosby, 1999, p3), and have been determined by some as being

particularly important in Afro-American oral tradition. An example of spiritual rhetoric may be seen via a fragment of a speech by the Rev. Martin Luther King, Jr., in 1963, a demand for civil rights:

"We will not be satisfied until justice rolls down like the waters and righteousness like a mighty stream," (King cited Giddens, 1981, p261).

They are fundamental to the African tradition of the griot, in passing on meaning and cultural history, and as such link directly with them. They have also been thought to contain a lyrical structure very similar to that of the blues, e.g.:

No more driver call me,

No more driver call.

No more driver call me,

Many thousand die.

(Barlow cited Crosby, 1999, p3. See also Appendix 1 for full citation of a spiritual).

Other constituent ingredients in the formation of the blues are "seculars," a song form that glorified the Afro-American, telling of daring escapes from the whites and chicken rustling for instance, and also complained of the hardships suffered and endured by them. The content of seculars, although not religious, tie in with the content of pleading for redemption and freedom expressed by the spirituals. The seculars could be deemed under a Marxist analogy as being conflictual, the spirituals anomic. Secondly, "field-hollers" and "arhoolies" which began in the fields. Few recordings are thought to exist and the testimony of old bluesmen [sic] have to be relied upon for proof of their existence. Bluesman Son House is an example of one and has been cited as saying that field hollers

and arhoolies were 'not real singing, you know, just hollering. But we made up our songs about things that were happening to us at the time, and I think that's where the blues started,' (House cited Crosby, 1999, p4. See also Oliver, 1990, pp16-28), literally a recording of history in a manner of speaking. It has also been suggested that it is the vocal techniques of field hollering and arhoolies that 'formed the basis of early blues vocals,' (Crosby, 1999, p4). Thirdly, "worksongs," which are thought to be derivative of West African tradition and therefore relate directly back to the griot, were used to co-ordinate and set up a working rhythm in the fields. The rhythms reflecting the repetitive nature of their labour. These rhythms and cross-rhythms are determined as having found their way into the blues. To create an image of these worksongs picture the drudgery of picking cotton in a large cotton field in the Mississippi Delta. Singing, hollering, (call), replying, (response), and moving to rhythms would surely alleviate, to an extent, the boredom of such monotonous, hard work.[2]

These parts, taken in isolation, fit together over a period of evolution, cultural interaction and shared experience, creating a whole. A new cultural music is formed that has been built upon tradition. The music acts as a form of social protest, a means of expression and cultural identity. A particularly important tool for the Afro-American in maintaining and celebrating their culture during the oppressive days of slavery and later the wage slavery of levee work and sharecropping. It must therefore be meaningful and authentic.

As an illustration of recurring themes, (historical record keeping), Oliver compares a song collected by Lafcadio Hearn circa 1876, called *Limber Jim*, to show the 'persistence of traditional elements in black song which have been sustained through periods of change:

[2] Think also of contemporary musical forms such as "techno" with its industrial sound and repetitive beat. A reflection, perhaps, of the precise nature and sound of modern factory production?

"Nigger an' a white man playing seven-up

White man played an' ace; an nigger feared to take it up,

White man played ace an' nigger played a nine,

White man died, an' nigger went blind."

Fifty years later Julius Daniels recorded in Atlanta, Georgia:

"Nigger an' a white man playin' seven-up this mornin',

Nigger an' a white man playin' seven-up this mornin'

Nigger an' a white man playin' seven-up

Well nigger win the money but he scared to pick it up,

This mornin' that' too soon for me."'

(Oliver, 1997, p22)

It not only shows the tradition of passing stories on but also shows the pervasive, oppressive relationship between white as master over the black. To this extent the blues and its contents can be seen as a social, cultural and individual protest against oppression and remain as historical accounts of time and place.

Migratory Dissemination

The blues is also a truly migratory music. It's traditions, based in Africa, reformulated via the slave population in the Southern states of America, then migrating North after the American Civil War and during the 20th Century to the new industrial cities of, for example, Chicago, Detroit, New York and St Louis. During its movement it took on a new form from that of the country blues to that of the urban blues, and the continuation of drawing on and reinventing the blues while assimilating other styles eventually gave us jazz, rock 'n' roll, r & b, rap, hip-hop etc. Baraka explains:

'... the music changes when the people change - it develops as the people develop, and reflects the development and the twists and turns of those lives that create it. Black music moves from African to African with some foreign elements (English, Spanish, French, Native American), becomes work songs, becomes more "Americanized." It becomes Afro-Christian at one point, and develops spirituals. And the secular, the nonreligious develops as well, sung tales, poems, the hollers, shouts, arhoolies that are the parents and later form of developed blues,' (Baraka, 1982, p179).

To make a summary of the above content it can be seen that slaves, brought to the U.S. and also the Carribean, were done so in order to be used as 'part of the colonial economy of imperialism,' (Brake, 1985, p116). They were an essential workforce on the large plantations where African culture was deliberately suppressed by American legislature: 'Their names and languages were forbidden,' (Brake, 1985, p116). But, although percussive instrumentation such as drums were not allowed through the fear that the slaves would communicate with each other, as they did in the African subcontinent, and rise up, 'the subversive element of African music remained,' (Brake, 1985, p117), and combined through West African worksongs with the 'religious and folk music of the New World,' (Brake, 1985, p117). This mixture of musical influence became American in context so as to veil the African roots which were kept intact. It has also been offered that 'Even the rhythm and syntax of Southern black accents can be traced to West African dialects,' (Brake, 1985, p117), and that 'what arose and was reproduced [the blues] was the personal experience of Afro-American people,' (Brake, 1985, p117). Billie Holiday's *Strange Fruit* may exemplify this notion, (See Appendix 4).

The formation of the blues, some have tried to argue, is the formation of a minority cultural music that through dissemination via records, the radio, the phonograph, mass production techniques and standardisation, became readily available to a much wider

audience. As it formed and became popular it also fragmented creating other musical forms that are directly related to the "parent" form. We have noted that the blues was not only popular amongst the Afro-American culture but that the vaudeville form was also popular amongst black and white, e.g. Billie Holiday, her white contemporary's would have been Sinatra and Crosby. The fragmentation of the blues into other forms, (the urban blues and jazz), 'are more accessible because postslavery black people are more accessible to Americans in general, rather than just their masters on plantations,' (Baraka, 1982, p182). He also suggests that there was more mobility for blacks after the American Civil War meaning the experiences they could sing about were much broader. 'So the people, the experience (content), and the music (form) are more available by the end of the nineteenth century,' (Baraka, 1982, pp182-183).

In conclusion of this brief history of the formation of a musical type we can see how the blues has developed and we end at the point where many Afro-Americans migrated from the harsh working regimes in the South to the industrial cities and ghetto's of the North of America, bringing with them the blues. Within the city and black ghetto's the blues took on different forms and was "discovered" as being a popular, authentic music of a specific culture, that of the Afro-American. It reflects through lyrical content and musical form tradition, history, emotion and meaning and changes as circumstance and technology change. It is a definitively evolutionary and dialectical music that has been influenced via environment and social change. It has fragmented and influenced other musical forms, hybridizing into jazz, soul, gospel, doo wop, be bop, rock 'n' roll, rhythm and blues, swing, funk, boogie woogie, disco, rap, hip hop, jungle and many other forms. Oliver states:

'So pervasive has been the influence of the blues on pop music since the early 1960's that it is already difficult to recognise it. Once the twelve-bar, three line structure was peculiar to the blues; now it is commonplace,' (Oliver, 1997, p1).

The commercialisation of the blues may well have opened the music up to a larger audience (including a white one), but did not necessarily save it as an art form that was on the brink of dying out - it would have remained a cultural or "folk" music of black communities. However, whether authentic or not, by the end of the 1920's 'Blacks would form in line [outside the phonograph stores], anxious to obtain the latest blues disc fresh from the presses,' (Oliver, 1990, p2), or buy them from any manner of black businesses. 'This was their music, the blues of their own race, and families that could ill-afford to do so, bought their phonographs and surrendered their seventy-five cents a time for the records,' (Oliver, 1990, pp2-3). Meanwhile, record companies were crying out for more representatives to handle the demand as the whole of black America seemed to echo 'to the rocking, moaning, hollering, singing of the blues ...,' (Oliver, 1990, p3). The blues had not only become a black cultural music it had also become big business with a potential mass market waiting to consume a product, a product made of their own culture and social history and which by the 1950' s had been assimilated by white American youth in the guise of rock 'n' roll before migrating back across the Atlantic via radio and record to the shores of Britain.

CHAPTER 3

Mass Culture: An Invention Of Industrialisation?

Mass Product

The characteristics of, in our sense, Western societies are identified as being economic, political, social and cultural. Music falls under the auspices of culture which is defined as being a form of civilisation and civilisation is a stage in the 'evolution of society,' (Liebeck and Pollard, 1997, p89). Society is regarded as being an organised community with rules and regulations which are arrived at through agreement by a polity. The polity, or government, form policies - described as being 'general plans of action,' (Liebeck and Pollard, 1997, p397), that legitimise the rules and regulations of that particular society. The discussion on polity becomes political. Politics, defined as meaning good judgement, is not limited to one stance; there may be many different points of view. However, through discussion agreement may be arrived at as to what constitutes the general truths upon which society should be founded, due to the holism being regarded as "greater than the sum of their parts." This is termed "reductionism" and is arguably a Western, objective and rational modern "ism" under which Capitalism and Democracy have been founded.

It is, in the West, a reality that we live in a Capitalist society that survives through the production and distribution of goods that are dependent upon invested private capital and profit-making. Under a Marxist rhetoric we may see that the formation of music that has a "mass market" appeal necessarily means that music is a consumable product. For it to be consumed it has to be produced for and distributed to the marketplace. Production and

consumption therefore become constant variables in a modern society and form the economic base. That is, we generally think of ourselves as producers or consumers, a situation that was not, in general, true before industrialisation. 'As economic production shifted from the field to the factory the family, [or in the case of Afro-American slaves], no longer worked together as a unit,' (Toffler, 1980, p44). It became fragmented, torn apart by the migration to the cities, battered by economic storms, families stripped themselves of unwanted relatives, grew smaller, more mobile, and more suited to the needs of the new techno-sphere,' (Toffler, 1980, p44), and we arrive at the so called nuclear family. A standard, 'socially approved, "modern" model in all industrial societies, whether capitalist or not,' (Toffler, 1980, pp44-45), that consume and produce product.

The above narrative hopefully illustrates what was happening to the Afro-American culture in the U.S. during the late 19th to the early and mid 20th Century. It is much the same as was happening or had happened in every industrialising or industrialised country of the world and therefore hopefully illuminating a universal thread. The thread being that a break up of the extended family to that of the nuclear family via industrialistion and migration leads to a fracturing of society. The fractured societies recongregate in the urban, industrial metropolis' in an attempt to reform community as well as looking for better paid jobs. However, the multigenerational community cannot be recreated as it has generally been left behind so what's been maintained and carried through are, as mentioned earlier, traditions such as music, that incorporate the history and identity of a social group:

'Blacks in the big cities were homesick for the kind of music they had left behind in the South, a point not lost on Perry Bradford, a vaudeville pianist, songwriter and bandleader based in New York. More sophisticated blacks, who had made a new life for themselves, ostensibly despised the blues as working class, an unwelcome memory of an oppressive system from which they had been lucky to escape. But Bradford believed there was still money in the blues, and in 1918 put together a blues revue called "Made In Harlem." It played to packed houses,' (Harrison, 1994, p22).

We have a music that has remained popular, recalls past and present events, evokes feelings of community, expresses meaning and is saleable to a mass market. By definition we have a "mass culture" that will consume a product. To satisfy a mass market you need to supply "en masse" a product and due to industrialisation mass production techniques made this possible, in the case of Afro-American music it was the mass production and manipulation of the blues. It is also identifiable, however, that when talking about mass culture we are also talking about popular culture. Just as we talk about the blues as being a specific form of music, but through analysis discover that it is not, that the blues is actually a reductionist term for a multifaceted genre, then we must also realise that when talking about mass or popular culture we are also talking about a diverse and not a singular entity. That is, mass culture implies that society is undifferentiated and that culture 'is reduced to the lowest level of taste,' (Abercombie et al, 1994, p253). As we can see from the above citation although the blues was popular it was also despised by the "more sophisticated" Afro-Americans as being "working-class, an unwelcome memory of an oppressive system." We have a hierarchy developing, fragmenting the culture, that is identifiable through the products they consume, e.g. jazz or blues; and the ideology they foster.

Consumer Culture

The contemporary world appears to be obsessed with product. Where people were once described as being citizens or the public they are now described as being consumers or members of a consumer society that is not only local but also becoming global. It has been said that it is the consumption, acquisition or purchase of various commodities and the development of particular forms of lifestyle 'that are increasingly being used as markers of social position,' (Abercombie et al, p84, 1994). What you own, buy, spend your leisure time doing is what you are, regardless of class, gender or race. It would under this analysis appear that the image or identity an individual portrays or creates of themselves within the social world reflects an aspiration toward some form of status or cultural grouping. To successfully portray the desired image the necessary products must be purchased. It is also observable that many products are sold via the use of music and image - take television advertising or commercial satellite television stations such as MTV and VH-1 for instance.

Products become no longer that of need but that of want, packaged and advertised as being needful or desirable. This consumer culture could be described as being anomic in that "existence is suffering, the cause of suffering being desire." Desire for products that allow us to portray our individuality. We can become anything or anybody if we culture our self into a particular mould. A recent newsworthy example was of a couple whom were obsessed with the 1940's. They moved into an old terraced house, purchased 40's clothing, household appliances and owned a 40's motor car. To all intents and purposes they live in a time capsule, a rejection of late 20th Century technological

culture to return to what they may perceive as being a simpler, less complicated lifestyle. Others of course have different identities they wish to foster, for instance the new rich, or upwardly mobile members of society. They snap up formerly aristocratic or upper class homes in desirable and prestigious towns and villages. Attend charity balls, do lunch, organise débutante balls and buy titles; setting themselves up as the new aristocracy. In effect replicating, or becoming simulacrums of those they have replaced. They have bought an identity and assimilated a different value system.

This may be quite a convincing notion in that due to shorter working hours in the West after the Second World War, people had more leisure time than ever before and arguably more disposable income. They therefore have the means and time to pursue and make real their "daydreams." However, it has been argued that although modern societies have some of these characteristics it is not clear that they have all of them. Also, it can only be hypothesised as to what the significance of such a culture has or whether or not such a culture is welcome, (Abercombie et al, 1994). Despite the supposition that such a culture exists and that such a culture may empower consumers and close class divides 'many writers believe that such a culture simply represents the extension of capitalist values and further divides the rich from poor,' (Abercombie et al, 1994). That is, only a minority of society has the means to pursue the culture of consumption to the extent of that supposed. So although "keeping up with the Jones'" may be a cultural fact for some, it may not be a way of life for most. People are therefore more likely to live within their means, suggesting that class, gender, and race remain the premier determinant of social divisiveness although these structures may have blurred. The consumer culture could then be perceived as also being a reductionist term or term reliant on the popular aspirations and affordability of different stratas of society.

Popular Culture - A Slight Return

The argument surrounding popular culture is particularly important. Abercombie et al describes it as being 'Loosely referred to as the culture of the masses or of subordinate classes,' (Abercombie et al, 1994, p320). Jim McGuigan states that 'any form of culture that appeals to ordinary people could quite reasonably ... be called populist culture,' (McGuigan, 1992, p2). Roy Shuker believes that '"popular" is a contested term. For some it means simply appealing to the people, whereas for others it means ... grounded in or of the people,' (Shuker, 1994, p3). Cutler, quite unhelpfully but probably correctly states that 'of course the ambiguity lies in the word popular,' (Cutler, 1991, p4). That is, does it mean, in the case of popular music, the most listened to, the most bought, the most attended, etc.?

We can gather from these smatterings of definitions that the term "popular" is contested and not only that the term "culture" may often have several meanings or possess meanings that are deeply ambiguous. Adorno for instance believed that "popular culture" was 'trivial, commercialised and passive,' (Abercombie, 1994, p320), and equated it to "mass culture." The culture of the masses within Adorno's meaning refers to the proletariat or working class majority and according to Featherstone it implies that 'the most evident thing about the common people is that there are so many of them,' (Feathertone, 1991, p134). Also, historically the use of the term "masses" equates to the "mob." It may therefore be supposed that the Frankfurt School identifies the masses 'with the urban, industrial lower orders and working people, the gullible, low herd, which formed a perpetual threat to culture,' (Featherstone, 1991, pp134-135), a pre-occupation, also, of the Leavisites. Although, for the Frankfurt Schools theorists, it was a reaction to

the Nazi party and mass following, in Germany, during the mid 1930's to the end of the Second World War. However, it is identifiable that if there is such a thing as a popular, mass, low culture, in opposition will be a high minority culture. This high minority culture is deemed to be interested not in the economic viability of populist, mass culture, (although in a Capitalist system, as indeed a Communist one, the health of the economic base is paramount), but in the aesthetics of culture. Culture in this sense is equated to the arts. That is music, literature and fine art. However, those that have the ability to partake in this form of aestheticism are generally those that have the economic ability to do so. For the masses it is something to aspire to - a case of hegemony, divide and rule, the creation of a false consciousness:

"The field of popular culture is structured by the attempt of the ruling class to win hegemony and by forms of opposition to this endeavor. As such it consists not simply of an imposed mass culture that is coincident with dominant ideology, nor simply of spontaneously oppositional cultures, but is rather an area of negotiation between the two within which - in different particular types of popular culture - dominant, subordinate and oppositional culture and ideological values and elements are "mixed" in different permutations," (Bennett cited Storey, 1997, p14).

Popular art, music and literature may be perceived as being lesser than the minority forms of culture. That is, the opposite of popular is unpopular. The sense of this is paradoxical as high culture, whilst being seen by the minority as being by the civilised and therefore capable of civilising society, is deemed unpopular by the majority. Under a traditional Marxist analysis high culture may be determined as being the bastion of privilege, the culture of the elite - it may therefore follow, under a neo-Marxist logic, that the majority should embrace elitist culture to remove them from the dominance that the minority have over them, but fails to acknowledge that by stating this they are also encouraging anomic

aspirations; bypassing the debate surounding the labelling of subordinate cultures by the elite and within the structurated, proletarian culture itself. That is, the elite will always maintain the belief that they are the harbingers of civilisation, espousing that the "masses" have attempted to hijack or assimilate "their" aestheticism and values and therefore hold them as always being oppositional. Culture may therefore become an important argument in identifying socio-economic class.

However, what has not been pointed out is that in music, for instance, you do not have to be of the elite of society to enjoy a symphony by Beethoven or of lower class to enjoy a song by the Spice Girls for example. A case in point is the late Princess of Wales who was documented as saying that she was a fan of pop groups Wham and Duran Duran in the 1980's. It may also be wise to point out that, as previously mentioned, terms such as folk culture, popular culture, mass culture and indeed, terms such as the blues, are reductionist paradigms. 'There are no masses; their are only ways of seeing people as masses,' (Williams cited Featherston, 1991, p135). That is, there is no one homogenous common culture that depicts one way of life, it is simply a variable that can be used to criticise generally the 'divided and fragmented culture we actually have,' (Featherstone, 1991, p134).

Youth Cultue

To illustrate, in recent times in Britain we have had youth cultures such as the Teds, Mods, Rockers, Skinheads, Hippies and Punks. These youth movements/cultures were seen as dangerous and anti-social but they were not necessarily mass, common cultures they may merely have been expressions or reflections of a fragmented society. They may all have been seen at some time as having been 'engaged in forms of cultural struggle against the homogenizing forces of incorporation of the official or dominant culture,' (Storey, 1997, p14), but it could be said that this is historically typical of youth cultures making a stand against the older generation, or "parent culture,"and their values. That is, regardless, in some respects, of being simply class biased oppositions, they are intrinsic opposition to dominant values within the close and wider social structure and may be better described as heterogeneous rather than homogenous. This may be supported by Giddens who believes that we are only aware of youth culture as being something homogenous due to 'Newspapers, books, radio, television, films, recorded music and popular magazines [that] bring us into close contact with experiences of which we would otherwise have little awareness,' (Giddens, 1980, p79).

These media, or culture industries, may be seen as doing little more than offering an alternative, safe culture for youth to join. This culture may be censored or lambasted by the self-prescribed gatekeepers of society, (establishment, parents, media etc.), if thought of as being too subversive before youth enter the realms of orthodox, productive adulthood. Under this analysis youth culture could quite easily be seen as being conservative and commercialised, manipulated to allow youth to feel that they are opposing authority, but are in actuality being conditioned to purchase goods and adopt

consumer trends that keeps Capital in power. However, being involved within and being accepted by a culture may give credence and realism to an individuals daydream.

Rebellious Youth

'The young people of today love luxury. They have bad manners, they scoff at authority and lack respect for their elders. Children nowadays are real tyrants, they no longer stand up when their elders come into the room where they are sitting, they contradict their parents, chat together in the presence of adults, eat gluttonously and tyrannise their teachers,' (Socrates cited Brake, 1980, p1).

Contemporary youth culture was born in the 1950's with the emergence of rock 'n' roll. It appears to be a watershed in the visibility of youth due, in the main, to their relative affluence after the Second World War, affording them the ability to buy and listen to this new music; a music that was considerably different to that of their parents. It could quite conceivably be described as a culture shock. The opposition to rock 'n' roll:

'shows how appalled 1950's observers automatically equated the rhythm of rock 'n' roll with savagery of various sorts ... Adolescents were, it seemed, "definitely influenced in their lawlessness by this throwback to jungle rhythms. Either it actually stirs them to orgies of sex and violence ... or they use it as an excuse for the removal of all inhibitions and the complete disregard of the conventions of decency,"' (Frith, 1998, p129).

It is apparent, here that youth has been seen as being synonymous with deviancy. Not only that, in the case of rock 'n' roll it was the incorporation of "blackness," the "primitiveness" and "savagery" of the "negro" into the culture of white youth - rock 'n' roll was labelled as being "regressive." This may be due to the racism that was endemic in rock 'n' roll. That is, the notion that black music is primitive (based on rhythm) and that it has not yet progressed or evolved to the level of European music.

What becomes apparent here is "action." Music requires involvement and 'is defined by its performance ... The African musician thinks of music primarily as action, as process, in which all are able to participate,' (Frith, 1998, p137). It is not dominated, as European music is in being 'composed by one person and performed to listeners by another. [It also disregards the belief that] "Pieces" of music ... exist over and above any possible performance of them," (Small cited Frith, 1998, p137). Imagine then the horror of the white moral majority witnessing "their" youth dancing to, emulating and copying black music and musicians!

CHAPTER FOUR

Protest As Product

Punk Rock

In a similar way to the evolution from African folk music to that of rock 'n' roll, punk rock met its moral opponents. British punk rock, as rock 'n' roll, was also seen to be a watershed in illuminating British popular music and popular culture. The British public became aware of punk during the mid 1970's and generally associated it 'with a creative and/or troublesome minority of "deviants" or "innovators,"' (Hebdidge, 1988, p212). Obviously depending on which side of the wall you were standing.

'Marsh (1977) saw the punk movement as "dole queue rock," drawn from the ranks of unemployed youth who despised superstars, complex electronic music, musical technical virtuosity and high prices for concerts, all of which emphasised the gaps between commercial musicians and unemployed fans,' (Brake, 1985, p77). There was also a structure within the movement. A lower middle class art school contingent and a hard, working class element. The art school types were perceived as being the innovators, and unsurprisingly the working class kids were seen as being the deviants, the troublesome, unlawful mob. An obvious case of prejudice and stereotyping, as Savage describes punk as being a 'breakthrough [in uniting] people who saw pop in terms of social realism and those who viewed it as artistic expression,' (Savage, p202, 1991).

The period in which punk came to the fore was set against a background of urban, working class, youth unemployment, national recession and the rise of New Right

ideology - themes and topics of punk songs and lyrics, e.g. *Career Opportunities* (The Clash) and *Seventeen* (The Sex Pistols). Punk was also ideologically set against the elitism of rock super groups such as Led Zeppelin, Deep Purple, etc., which they believed were phallocentric and were out of touch with social reality; eluding to some sort of sense of "high art." Punk aimed to recapture meaning and 'retreat from the phallocentric codes of "cock rock,"' (Hebdidge, 1988, p213), by resurrecting "marginalised" musics such as bebop, r & b etc., and also aimed to have a political theology. They were opposed to concepts of for instance 'a "United Kingdom" in songs like *White Riot* (The Clash), *Anarchy In The U.K.* (The Sex Pistols),' (Hebdidge, 1988, p213), *Alternative Ulster* (Stiff Little Fingers), and an allegience was formed with political groups such as the Anti-Nazi League and Rock against Racism campaign.

Punk was also driven by the belief in sexual equality and were tolerant of homo-sexuality, etc. Due to this they 'became the enemies of the skinheads,' (Brake, 1985, pp77-78), and also of the resurgent Teds, who although listened to and identified with "black music" were frequently involved in unprovoked attacks on immigrant West Indian communities. The Teds figured prominently in the 1958 race riots and during the height of Punk were famously involved in running battles with them on London's Chelsea Road. Certain factions of the skinhead subculture were and still are associated with right wing organisations such as the N.F. in the 1970's and its spin-off, latterly, as the BNP. These right wing groups, other than being racist, are also malecentric, seeing women as second-class citizens, disability and homosexuality as being something unnatural and alien.

Punk rock openly embraced black culture using reggae and incorporating "Dread" and rastafarian belief systems to give tangible form to their alienation, e.g. *Roots, Radic*[al]*s, Rockers And Reggae* (Stiff Little Fingers), *Police And Thieves* (The Clash), *I Feel Like A Wog* (The Stranglers):

'It carried the necessary conviction, the political bite, so obviously missing in white music ... the colours, the locks, the patois - was awesome and forbidding, suggesting as it did an impregnable solidarity, an asceticism born of suffering ... patois had been spoken for centuries beneath the Masters comprehension ... and the themes of Back to Africa and Ethiopianism ... made no concessions to the sensibilities of a white audience. Reggae's blackness ... was an alien essence ... which implicitly threatened mainstream British culture from within and as such resonated with punk's adopted values - "anarchy", "surrender" and "decline",' (Hebdidge, 1989, pp63-64).

Punk could be seen as a disavowal of Britishness their 'aesthetic can be read in part as a white translation of black ethnicity,' (Hebdidge, 1989, p64). Punk stood against the perceived divisiveness and racism of the British class system and its establishment, looking towards a value of acceptance of difference and allowance for individual expression. This meant an all out attack on the establishment, which included traditionalist subcultures, the media, teachers, parents, the police, politicians, the aristocracy and the monarchy. The belief was that traditional values must be contested to force a revolution of consciousness and the punk movement could be deemed as having been a latter day Digger movement. An anarchic, agrarian faction of Cromwell's Levellers and New Model Army of the English Civil War, reborn via the alienation, segregation and oppression felt by youth within the decaying, jobless urban centres of the cities. As Storey states:

'... race, gender, region, generation, sexal preference, etc. - all are at different moments engaged in

forms of cultural struggle against the homogenizing forces of incorporation of the official or dominant culture,' (Storey, 1997, p14).

Punk rock reflected this alienation and decay in their music and performance with a "back to basics" ideology, (a term later adopted by Punks enemies - Powellite and Thatcherite New Right politics), and the paradoxical use of apathy and aggression. This was later heightened by the use of sub/dom styles of dress, body piercing, grotesque facial make-up, the use and perversion of Nazi symbolism and a come as you are, do it yourself, be yourself attitude. The protest was just as much an appearance (style) and attitude as a music and was a brief but powerful youth phenomenon. The aim was to shock and question the "birth, school, work, death" ethic of existence which eventually uncovered the age old paradox's between socialism and anarchism. Confusions that punk ideology was chaotically attempting to reconcile.

'Punk was trafficking in taboos at the same time as it sought to illuminate and dramatize deep-seated contradictions with a sophisticated, ironic rhetoric. Unlike many historical avant-garde movements, it had the potential to enter the mass market and in November 1976, was poised to do so. But the mass market is notorious for simplifying complexities and steam rollering irony and the idea of a youth movement with swastikas hitting "the kids" was simply terrifying,' (Savage, 1991, p243).

The usual suspects were of course the Sex Pistols.

God Save History

The Sex Pistols were the first Punk band to be signed to a major record label, EMI,. Most other signed punk bands were on small independent labels, much the same as early blues musicians, many were never signed and many more would form only for one "gig." EMI

dropped the Pistols in January 1977, (See Appendix 7), after the furore surrounding their well documented interview on Bill Grundy's *Today* Show, (See Appendix 6), in December 1976, and the following publicity it was given in the national press. All but three of their twenty-one tour dates were cancelled and DJ's refused to play their single *Anarchy In The U.K.* except notably John Peel. However, the single sold more than 50, 000 copies and *Anarchy* entered the top twenty just before Christmas, 1976. Although dropped by EMI the attention surrounding the Sex Pistols and punk greatly interested the music industry and general public (particularly youth), proving that if nothing else 'a good scandal can generate a great deal of free publicity,' (Garofalo, p321, 1996).

The dropping of the Sex Pistols cost EMI £50, 000. A&M picked them up for a further £50, 000 and dropped them a week later, costing them a further £25, 000. Richard Branson's label Virgin then took them on. Their first release for Virgin was *God Save The Queen*, (See Appendix 5), of which some have said was deliberately designed to coincide with the Queens Silver Jubilee celebrations. Its accusation that the monarchy and the establishment were members of "a fascist regime" appeared all the more insightful when CBS printing plant workers refused to handle the single, radio and television stations refused to advertise it, 'retail outlets refused to place orders, and the single ... was banned from the airwaves,' (Garofalo, p321, 1996). This paradoxically provided more publicity and media attention. The single was finally released late May 1977, just ahead of the Jubilee celebrations. It was 'selected as "Single of the Week" by all four British music weeklies,' (Garofalo, 1996, p321), and despite its ban had sold over 20, 000 copies by the end of the Jubilee week, eventually charting at No.2 in the pop charts. It's expected No.1 position never materialising due to proved sales manipulation to keep it off the top within the industry itself.

God Save The Queen has been described as the 'only serious critique of the Jubilee,' (Garofalo, 1996, p321), and members of the Sex Pistols were seriously, physically attacked during this period. It appeared that the Pistols' anarchic rhetoric had 'uncovered cracks in the social facade that had been remarkably well covered over by official pomp and ceremony,' (Garofalo, 1996, p321). Their verbal attack on the establishment thrusting them up against the wall to be shot at by the politics of the real world. Anarchism was a little too hot to handle:

'To describe the essential theory of anarchism is rather like trying to grapple with Proteus, for the very nature of the libertarian attitude - its rejection of dogma, its deliberate avoidance of systematic theory, and, above all, its stress on extreme freedom of choice and on the primacy of the individual judgement - creates immediately the possibility of a variety of viewpoints inconceivable in a closely dogmatic system,' (Woodcock cited Savage, 1991, p27).

The Sex Pistols had not only questioned mainstream values by espousing the rhetoric of a kinetic, shifting paradigm that had no dogmatic, formulated rules but had also exposed the music industry as being profit motivated and interested only in capitalising on trends. They had also upset the musical standards of the time by throwing up 'a series of insults and rejections [at a time when song dealt mainly with] the pop archetypes of escape and [idealised] love,' (Savage, 1991, p206). The Sex Pistols and the Punk movement in general mainly dealt in ideological sloganeering rather than reproducing commercial pop sentiments and it is this that may have created such an explosive conflict. However, its protest was soon packaged, produced and sold to an increasingly media hyped public. The Sex Pistols interview E.P. *Some Product* and the album released after their demise *Flogging A Dead Horse* encapsulating this notion.

Conclusion

In conclusion of this study and firstly in retrospect there are many areas that have been missed or are cloudy in reasoning, due in many respescts to my own lack of specialised, specific knowledge. It may have been better from a methodological point of view to have used more proactive methods of investigation, such as interviews or questionnaires, to discover others' views on music and what music means to them rather than relying purely on theoretical devices that will have been perjured by my own values. However, I feel the study is certainly of value as a text to be used as a reference to help further a more in-depth project at sometime in the future. I also feel that the attempt to identify links regarding social protest within popular music can be traced quite successfully to Africa, although the insinuation is not that this is where music, protest or otherwise, is derived from.

The question surrounding whether commercialistion of music genres removes meaning from the music has not been proven, although the recording and distribution of music to the market place will only be maintained if there is a market for it. This expresses a rationale that states that tried and tested formats will be maintained as a consumer market has been found. It is a similar logic to that of the production of motor cars for instance. Why change a successful model?

It can clearly be seen that lyrical content in popular music is not necessarily censored as seen in the lyrics of *Strange Fruit*, (1939), and *God Save The Queen*, (1977), (refer to appendices), but that certainly in the case of the Sex Pistols attempts were made to ban them from making public appearances and releasing their records, although this had the

opposite effect to the one intended. It must also be noted that Billie Holiday's career took a turn for the worse after releasing *Strange Fruit*, a song that she had turned down on previous occasions. This may have been due to the lyrical content, however this supposition is unsubstantiated.

I have some consternation that the 1950's and the advent of rock 'n' roll has not been adequately covered. Particularly in regard to its importance as a cultural cross-over point and that the ideological attacks on it as an uncivilising form of music followed by its eventual acceptance and incorporation into the white American culture has not been fully investigated. That is, why was the music eventually accepted? I feel the role of Elvis Presley and government controlled sections of the music industry in particular may uncover some clues! Also, in the same vein, rock 'n' roll's migration and initial lambasting by the British establishment and acceptace by youth, (as punk rock), needed a much more vigorous investigation. It may also have been wise to investigate, specifically, the growth of the record industry rather than enter a possibly over elaborate dialogue on industrialisation and mass production. That is, I feel this section of the study falls short of the mark in that I failed to overtly acknowledge that the music industry is directly responsible for the mass production of popular music, although it is suggested within the text and appendices.

Although my knowledge of discourse analysis is severely limited, I feel that by comparing two "protest" songs, (See Appendices), by popular artistes the notion that the music industry and dominant political ideology deliberately suppress such songs is untenable. It is however observable that there may be various problems in releasing such material and/or having it heard on radio or television. In fact, in the case of the Sex

Pistols, attempted suppression made the song *God Save The Queen* something of a curiosity and quite probably increased the demand for the record. A similar case in the late 1980's was that of Frankie Goes To Hollywood's *Relax*, which, although banned from air play became a No1. hit single.

The case that political ideology uses music for their own devices is certainly not a new hypothesis. Music is and has been used in propaganda films, e.g. the Allies and the Nazis during the Second World War. Every country has a National Anthem, (See Appendix 2), and every football team has a mass of fans chanting and singing, supporting their team whilst doing down the opposition. It also been seen recently that Tony Blair invited musicians such as Noel Gallagher of "Oasis," (compared to the Sex Pistols), and Mick Hucknall of "Simply Red," to a party at No.10 Downing Street. Possibly a move to show the nation that he is in touch with the "kids." He also gave Geri Halliwell, ex of the Spice Girls, a high profile job working with the Culture Minister, and it may be worthwhile pointing out here that the British Music Industry is today worth £2billion to the national economy.

In the case of the Sex Pistols, (described as the most important thing to happen to British music since the Beatles), who were a particularly successful pop group with a political ideology, it may be seen that they were a flash in the pan. That is, it's observable by watching and listening to the pop charts that in general music within the mainstream does not concern itself with social protest, at least not as overtly as the Sex Pistols. It tends to err towards more orthodox themes such as falling in love, although some mainstream pop groups may use language to covertly express their message, by either using words that have meaning only within certain sub-cultures or by cleverly hiding meaning within the

context of a song subject that is seemingly neutral. That is, although these songs may be seen as being simply regurgitations of age old topics and are possibly trapped within standard forms of music due in part to the rules of structure in language and also rules of structure in music, (that are observably standardised), it does not mean that they are devoid of meaning. Also, a song, whether one of love or one of protest, is popular only if people are moved enough to buy it. It may also be supposed that the content of songs of protest may not always be contextually understood by the buying public.

Finally, I feel that was has become apparent during this study is that music within society has always been that of humans attempting to convey meanings through story telling and expressing feelings such as love, anger, alienation, oppression and hate; and that song is also a useful tool for recording history. It moves you emotionally, touches your soul, encourages thought, makes you want to dance, or sit back and relax. It has an energy that can pull people together from different cultural, socio-economic and ethnic backgrounds, as it gives people commonality; (maybe this is the power of standardisation?) It may therefore be a logical supposition to suggest that music and song which effects individuals either positively or negatively can never be benign or thought of as unmeaningful.

The value and power of music is also likely to have been recognised by politicians, the owners of the means of production and the gatekeepers of society. Certain music may therefore become targeted, censored or banned; generally that which may be thought to be a threat to the natural order of things. It becomes labelled as immoral, deviant, anarchic or subversive, which, as we have seen, may have an opposite effect to the one intended. That is, instead of neutralising the perceived threat to the status quo the attempt to censor

or ban particular forms of music may actually increase interest and consumption of that particular product.

However, the underlying problem with studying music in society is that it is something that has to be experienced and belongs to time and place. The music and content may therefore be much more powerful within its respective time period simply because it may be something new or express values that have not previously surfaced. Also, peoples sensibilities may not be able to cope with or keep up with fast social change and means of expression. Under this supposition it may be seen that youth are much more likely to accept change then their elders as they are in a process of making sense of the world. It may therefore be supposed that it is, amongst other socialising experiences, the music they listen to that speaks their language and gives them a sense of identity.

N.B.

As a cursory note I always find it amusing in attempting to identify old Teds, Mods, Rockers, Skins and Punks in public places. They are still all out there and are no doubt still consumers of music products and styles that they believe suit and express their particular belief systems. This may be why we have resurgences of music, styles, fashions and attitudes. Something that marketing men [sic] are not slow to package and sell, e.g. Britpop and Girlpower.

Appendix 1.

Go Down Moses

(Negro Spiritual)

Go down, Moses, way down in Egypt land,
Tell old Pharoah,
Let my people go!
When Israel was in Egypt land,
Let my people go,
Oppressed so hard they could not stand,
Let my people go!
Go down, Moses, way down in Egypt land,
Tell old Pharoah, let my people go!

Appendix 2.

Afro-American National Anthem

Lift Every Voice and Sing

Lift every voice and sing
Till earth and heaven ring,
Ring with the harmonies of Liberty;
Let our rejoicing rise
High as the listening skies,
Let it resound loud as the rolling sea.
Sing a song full of the faith that the dark past has taught us,
Sing a song full of the hope that the present has brought us,
Facing the rising sun of our new day begun
Let us march on till victory is won.

Stony the road we trod,
Bitter the chastening rod,
Felt in the days when hope unborn had died;
Yet with a steady beat,
Have not our weary feet
Come to the place for which our fathers sighed?
We have come over a way that with tears has been watered,
We have come, treading our path through the blood of the slaughtered,
Out from the gloomy past,
Till now we stand at last
Where the white gleam of our bright star is cast.

God of our weary years,
God of our silent tears,
Thou who has brought us thus far on the way;
Thou who has by Thy might
Led us into the light,
Keep us forever in the path, we pray.
Lest our feet stray from the places, Our God, where we met Thee,
Lest, our hearts drunk with the wine of the world, we forget Thee;
Shadowed beneath Thy hand,
May we forever stand.
True to our GOD,
True to our native land.

Appendix 3.

THE EMANCIPATION PROCLAMATION:

By the President of the United States of America.

A PROCLAMATION: Whereas on the 22nd day of September, A.D. 1862, a proclamation was issued by the President of the United States, containing, among other things, the following, to wit:

"That on the 1st day of January, A.D. 1863, all persons held as slaves within any State or designated part of a State the people whereof shall then be in rebellion against the United States shall be then, thenceforward, and forever free; and the executive government of the United States, including the military and naval authority thereof, will recognize and maintain the freedom of such persons and will do no act or acts to repress such persons, or any of them, in any efforts they may make for their actual freedom.

"That the executive will on the 1st day of January aforesaid, by proclamation, designate the States and parts of States, if any, in which the people thereof, respectively, shall then be in rebellion against the United States; and the fact that any State or the people thereof shall on that day be in good faith represented in the Congress of the United States by members chosen thereto at elections wherein a majority of the qualified voters of such States shall have participated shall, in the absence of strong countervailing testimony, be deemed conclusive evidence that such State and the people thereof are not then in rebellion against the United States."

Now, therefore, I, Abraham Lincoln, President of the United States, by virtue of the power in me vested as Commander-In-Chief of the Army and Navy of the United States in time of actual armed rebellion against the authority and government of the United States, and as a fit and necessary war measure for supressing said rebellion, do, on this 1st day of January, A.D. 1863, and in accordance with my purpose so to do, publicly proclaimed for the full period of one hundred days from the first day above mentioned, order and designate as the States and parts of States wherein the people thereof, respectively, are this day in rebellion against the United States the following, to wit:

Arkansas, Texas, Louisiana (except the parishes of St. Bernard, Palquemines, Jefferson, St. John, St. Charles, St. James, Ascension, Assumption, Terrebone, Lafourche, St. Mary, St. Martin, and Orleans, including the city of New Orleans), Mississippi, Alabama, Florida, Georgia, South Carolina, North Carolina, and Virginia (except the forty-eight counties designated as West Virginia, and also the counties of Berkeley, Accomac, Morthhampton, Elizabeth City, York, Princess Anne, and Norfolk, including the cities of Norfolk and Portsmouth), and which excepted parts are for the present left precisely as if this proclamation were not issued.

And by virtue of the power and for the purpose aforesaid, I do order and declare that all persons held as slaves within said designated States and parts of States are, and henceforward shall be, free; and that the Executive Government of the United States, including the military and naval authorities thereof, will recognize and maintain the freedom of said persons.

And I hereby enjoin upon the people so declared to be free to abstain from all violence, unless in necessary self-defence; and I recommend to them that, in all case when allowed, they labor faithfully for reasonable wages.

And I further declare and make known that such persons of suitable condition will be received into the armed service of the United States to garrison forts, positions, stations, and other places, and to man vessels of all sorts in said service. And upon this act, sincerely believed to be an act of justice, warranted by the Constitution upon military necessity, I invoke the considerate judgment of mankind and the gracious favor of Almighty God. ----------

On Jan. 1, 1863, U.S. President Abraham Lincoln declared free all slaves residing in territory in rebellion against the federal government. This Emancipation Proclamation actually freed few people. It did not apply to slaves in border states fighting on the Union side; nor did it affect slaves in southern areas already under Union control. Naturally, the states in rebellion did not act on Lincoln's order. But the proclamation did show Americans-- and the world--that the civil war was now being fought to end slavery.

Lincoln had been reluctant to come to this position. A believer in white supremacy, he initially viewed the war only in terms of preserving the Union. As pressure for abolition mounted in Congress and the country, however, Lincoln became more sympathetic to the idea. On Sept. 22, 1862, he issued a preliminary proclamation announcing that emancipation would become effective on Jan. 1, 1863, in those states still in rebellion. Although the Emancipation Proclamation did not end slavery in America--this was achieved by the passage of the 13TH Amendment to the Constitution on Dec. 18, 1865--it did make that accomplishment a basic war goal and a virtual certainty.

DOUGLAS T. MILLER

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